

From Concern to Action

An eight-page student toolkit for investigating a real issue, checking information, understanding power, and designing a useful first action.

A SOLUTIONARY INQUIRY

This toolkit does not begin with a teacher-chosen answer. Students notice a real situation, listen to affected people through safe and public sources, examine systems, verify claims, map decision-making power, and test one realistic action.

The five moves

1	Notice locally	Start with observation and questions.
2	Connect the system	Link people, land, history, rights, policy, and Global Goals.
3	Verify the story	Trace claims and compare credible evidence.
4	Map power	Find who is affected, who knows, and who decides.
5	Act and reflect	Test a useful action, measure change, and revise.

Before students begin

Choose an issue close enough to observe but not so personal that students must reveal private experiences. Build from public data, authentic community voices, optional surveys, and accessible participation. The goal is a change in conditions, access, understanding, policy, representation, or voice - not a performance of caring.

1. Frame the issue before solving it

Use observations, not assumptions. Separate what is known from what still needs investigation.

What are we noticing?

Describe the place, pattern, event, routine, claim, or concern. Include specific evidence you can observe.

What do we think we know?

List current ideas. Mark each as observation, interpretation, or question.

Who may be affected?

Name groups or roles without guessing anyone's identity or private experience. Whose public or voluntary input is needed?

Write an inquiry question

Use: How might we better understand and improve _____ while listening to _____ and considering _____?

2. Connect the system and the Global Goals

A useful systems map shows relationships. It does not force an issue into only one category.

People and lived knowledge

Who experiences the issue? Who has relevant lived, cultural, professional, or community knowledge?

Land and environment

What places, ecosystems, resources, health conditions, or responsibilities to future generations are involved?

History and systems

Which histories, policies, norms, routines, institutions, or resources shape what is happening now?

Rights and access

Which rights, barriers, responsibilities, or forms of participation are connected?

Which Global Goals help reveal connections?

Circle or list two to four Goals. Explain the relationship instead of choosing by title alone.

3. Verify the story

Use this routine for one claim, statistic, image, video, post, or article that matters to the inquiry.

PAUSE	What reaction is the message trying to create? What would happen if we shared it before checking?
TRACE	Can we find the original source, full context, date, author, organization, study, or data?
CHECK	What evidence is offered? What expertise or lived knowledge is relevant? Are important limits explained?
COMPARE	What do other credible and independent sources say? Where do they agree, disagree, or add context?

Our current judgment

Reliable enough to use / useful with limits / not supported yet. Explain why.

4. Map power, knowledge, and influence

People affected by an issue and people with formal decision-making power may not be the same. A fair inquiry notices both.

Group or role	Affected how?	Knowledge or perspective	Influence or decision power

Where could students have realistic influence?

Consider learning, communication, relationships, design, school routines, purchasing, events, policy requests, community partnerships, or public decision-making.

Who should guide or approve the next step?

Name people to listen to, partners to involve, permissions needed, and boundaries students should not cross.

5. Choose an action that fits the cause

Awareness can matter, but it is not the only kind of action. Choose a strategy connected to what the investigation revealed.

LEARN

Teach accurate context or correct a harmful misconception.

Possible idea:

DESIGN

Remove a physical, sensory, language, digital, or participation barrier.

Possible idea:

REPRESENT

Improve whose voices, stories, images, languages, or knowledge are present.

Possible idea:

ADVOCATE

Make an evidence-based request to a person or group with decision power.

Possible idea:

RESTORE

Repair or care for a relationship, place, habitat, resource, or shared trust.

Possible idea:

ORGANIZE

Build participation, gather wider input, or coordinate people around a shared goal.

Possible idea:

Our strongest first action

Choose the smallest useful action that addresses a cause or barrier and can be completed well.

6. Plan the first action

Make the action specific, shared, accessible, and small enough to finish. A first action is a test, not the final answer.

Our action and intended change

What will we do? What access, understanding, condition, policy, representation, relationship, or participation do we hope will change?

People and roles

Who will research, connect, design, communicate, organize, check care and access, and follow up?

Steps, materials, and timeline

List the next three to five steps, materials or support needed, and a realistic completion date.

Access, safety, and permission

How can people participate in different ways? What privacy, cultural guidance, adult approval, or risk checks are needed?

Evidence of impact

What will we observe, count, compare, ask, or document to learn whether the action helped?

7. Measure, share back, and reflect

A solutionary project is complete only when students return to the people and evidence that shaped it, explain what happened, and decide what comes next.

What happened?

Describe the action and include specific evidence of participation, response, or change.

Who benefited, who may still face barriers, and whose voice is still missing?

Use the intersectionality lens without guessing or requiring disclosure.

What did we learn about information and power?

Which sources became more or less trustworthy? Who could make decisions? What influenced the outcome?

How will we share back?

Explain what was heard, what was tried, what changed, what did not, and when people will receive another update.

Continue, change, or stop?

Choose the next step and explain why. Include one question the inquiry opened for future learning.
